

PRODUCT TEARDOWN

Upstox

From access to action: diagnosing the activation gap
and building the case for India's next 2.6M active investors

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About Upstox

2009

Founded

Mumbai HQ

13M+

Registered Users

As of 2025

#3

Broker Rank

By active clients

KEY INVESTORS

Ratan Tata

Tiger Global

Kalaari Capital

GVK Davix

Services: Stocks | Mutual Funds | ETFs | Digital Gold | Bonds | F&O | IPO | Commodities

Zero commission on Mutual Funds & IPOs. Flat brokerage on trades. Mobile + desktop platform.

Market Positioning

BEGINNER

EXPERT TRADER

BEGINNER



Groww

First-timer simplicity
Mobile-native, zero jargon
Owns top-of-funnel intent

THE MIDDLE



Upstox

More powerful than Groww
Friendlier than Zerodha
Largest unclaimed segment

EXPERT



Zerodha

Serious trader depth
Gold standard for F&O
Kite platform dominance

Millions of Indians are opening investment accounts and then doing nothing with them.

40-60%

of accounts never placed a trade

The access barrier has been broken. Digital KYC and flat-fee broking brought crores to the door.

The problem has shifted: from getting people in, to helping people act.

The Three Gaps

1

TOP OF FUNNEL

Discovery Gap

Aakash searches how to invest in stocks India - not Upstox. Groww owns these intent moments. Upstox wins on brand terms but loses top-of-funnel entirely. The first investor is not looking for a broker - they are looking for an answer.

2

ONBOARDING

Activation Gap

KYC failures, silent errors, and a 24-48hr wait create invisible walls. When the account finally opens, users land on a professional trader dashboard with no start-here moment and no guided first step.

3

RETENTION

Continuity Gap

After a first trade, users are completely on their own. Market drops show a red number and a Sell button with no context, no calming data, no behavioural guardrail. Panic-selling is frictionless.

The Business Case for Fixing This

The Opportunity

2.6M

More active investors at zero additional CAC
if activation improves from 40% to 60%

10X

ARPU generated by users who invest
for 12 consecutive months vs one-time traders

260Cr

Incremental year-one revenue from
fixing the dormant account rate

The Strategic Bet

OLD BET: Reduce cost → Increase access →
Monetise volume

**NEW BET: Reduce confusion → Increase
confidence → Monetise longevity**

*The frontier is not acquiring more Middle India Investors.
It is converting the ones already in the funnel.*

Personas

Aakash



24-34 yrs | Tier 2 City

Software Professional / Govt Employee

6-15L annual income

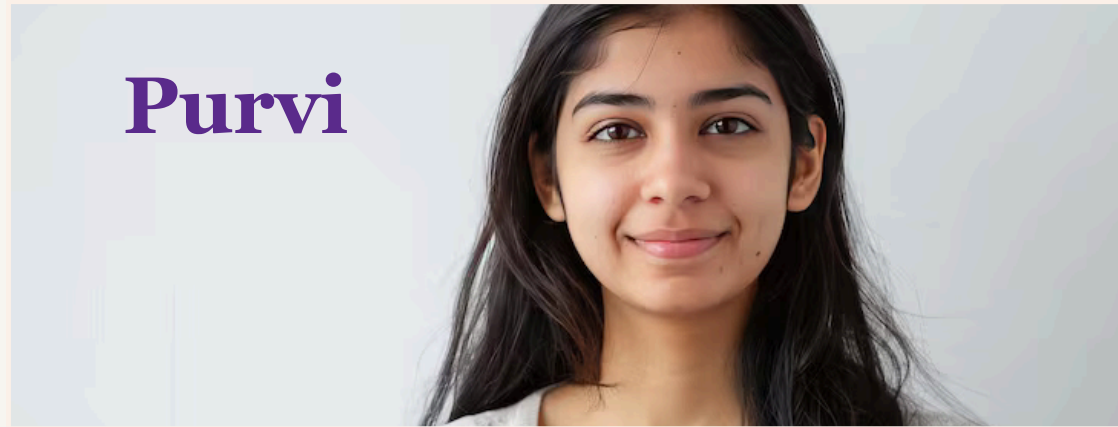
WANTS

- Simple entry
- Guidance on what should I buy?
- Reassurance - wont lose money?

FEARS

- Market crash
- Hidden fees
- Complexity

Purvi



28-42 yrs | Metro / Tier 1

IT / Business Owner / Ex-Banker

20L+ annual income

WANTS

- Fast execution
- Deep option chain
- GTT

FEARS

- App crash on Budget Day
- Incorrect orders
- Hidden charges

Dev



22-38 yrs | Any City

Software Engineer / Quant

Tech-native, API-focused

WANTS

- Reliable WebSocket
- Low-latency API access
- SDK in Python/JS

FEARS

- Downtime
- Poor docs
- No community

Why Prioritise Aakash?

71%

of Upstox users are first-time investors like Aakash

85%

of first-time investors come from Tier 2 / Tier 3 cities

35%

of new investors drop out during KYC alone

50%

of 13M users have NEVER placed a single trade

The Strategic Rationale

- Purvi's cohort generates more revenue today.
- Aakash's cohort generates more revenue over the next decade.
- Groww owns the beginner. Zerodha owns the expert.
- Aakash - the aspiring middle India investor who grows into sophistication - is the largest unclaimed segment.
- All Aakashs are already in the funnel. We have paid their CAC. Fixing activation is worth Rs 260Cr in year-one revenue.

Aakash's Journey Map

Trigger	Discovery	Onboarding	Activation	Early Habit	Market Shock
Rahul earns Rs 8K on Tata Motors. Aakash checks his idle Rs 15K savings earning 2.7%. <i>Motivation ignites.</i>	Searches 'how to invest in stocks India'. Finds Groww first. <i>Lands on Upstox via Rahul's referral link.</i>	PAN + Aadhaar + bank details. Name mismatch silently fails. No explanation. No recovery path. Abandons.	36-hr silence. Account opens. Trader dashboard. No start-here. Copies Rahul and buys Tata Motors.	Tata up Rs 340. Checks app 12x/day. <i>No nudge to diversify, set alerts, or start a SIP.</i>	Nifty drops 1200 pts. Portfolio red. App shows Sell button. <i>No context. Panic-sells. Goes dormant.</i>

KEY INSIGHT: Each stage has an undesigned moment that silently costs Upstox a user.

Pain Points at Each Stage

Discovery

Not present when intent is highest. Groww owns the search query 'how to invest in stocks India' entirely.

Activation

48-hour silence post-KYC. Trader UI shown to a first-time investor. No guided first step, no recommended action.

Market Shock

Red number + Sell button with no friction, no context, no historical recovery data. Panic-selling is frictionless.

Onboarding

Silent KYC failure on name mismatch between Aadhaar and bank records. No recovery path. 35% abandon here.

Early Habit

Zero guidance after the first trade. No milestones. Product treats a 7-day investor the same as a 7-year investor.

Long Term

No wealth progression. Same home screen at Rs 500 portfolio as at Rs 1,00,000. Product does not grow with Aakash.

10 Problems Identified

P1	Trigger No SEO ownership of 'how to invest' search intent	P6	Activation No paper trading or risk-free practice mode
P2	Onboarding Silent Aadhaar name mismatch - no recovery path	P7	Early Habit No guided 'what to do next' path after first trade
P3	Onboarding Silent Google Auth failure - no recovery path	P8	Mkt Shock No contextual intervention during portfolio drawdown
P4	Onboarding 24-48 hour activation wait is a cold, silent void	P9	Mkt Shock No sell-or-hold decision support at the critical moment
P5	Activation No new-investor home screen - default UI built for Purvi	P10	Long Term No wealth progression - product does not grow with Aakash

Prioritisation of Problems

Problem	Stage	Reach /Qtr	Impact	Conf%	Effort	RICE Score
P2 - Aadhaar name mismatch	KYC	7,000	3	100%	2w	10,500
P3 - Google Auth failure	KYC	3,000	3	100%	1w	9,000
P4 - Silent activation void	KYC	8,000	2	80%	2w	6,400
P5 - No new-investor home	Activation	8,000	3	80%	4w	4,800
P8 - No drawdown intervention	Mkt Shock	6,000	3	80%	3w	4,800
P9 - No sell decision support	Mkt Shock	4,000	3	80%	2w	4,800
P7 - No guided next step	Habit	5,000	3	80%	3w	4,000

Top 3 selected target the same funnel window: KYC completion to first trade placed

Solution Landscape

OKAY

Quick wins - unblock the funnel fast

- Fix CTA contrast bug (dark blue on black)
- Friendly error message for Google Auth failure
- Contextual 'why we need this' micro-copy
- Default new accounts to Investor mode
- Make Investor/Trader mode switch visible on home
- App accessibility: custom font size and display scaling

GOOD

High-confidence, meaningful impact

- Named error detection for Aadhaar mismatch + 3-path recovery
- 'Stuck?' support button at each KYC step after 90s
- 4-email activation drip sequence
- Risk profiling questionnaire during activation wait
- Onboarding intent screen (Beginner / Trader / Investor)
- 30-day new investor milestone journey checklist
- 'What should I buy?' curated starter collections
- WhatsApp-native activation updates

MOONSHOT

High effort, transformative potential

- AI-powered KYC failure diagnosis and auto-resolution
- Video KYC with live agent for edge cases
- Paper trading / virtual portfolio during activation wait
- AI stock detail page in plain language
- Dynamic home screen that grows with portfolio
- 'Upstox Wrapped' annual personalised report card

Top 3 Solutions Selected

S17**1 Day**

Highest RICE Score

Default New Accounts to Investor Mode

Affects 100% of new accounts. Single config change. Eliminates the primary reason Aakash sees a confusing dashboard and cannot find the Buy button. Zero engineering risk.

S1**1 Day**

RICE: 72,000

Fix CTA Contrast Bug

Dark blue Continue text on black background is literally invisible. 100% of new accounts blocked at KYC. One-day CSS fix. Every day this ships later is a measurable conversion loss.

S12**2 Weeks**

RICE: 57,600

4-Email Activation Drip Sequence

Bridges the 24-48 hour activation void. Educate, anticipate, prime, act. Converts cold arrivals into activated investors at 2-3x the baseline rate. Direct analogue proven at Groww.

All three attack the same funnel window - KYC completion to first trade - and compound each other.

MVP Plan

PHASE 1: INTERNAL SPRINT | Weeks 1-3 | No external spend | 3.5 engineer-weeks

S17

1 day

Default Investor Mode

Config change. Sets all new accounts to Investor mode. Foundation of the sprint.

S1

1 day

Fix CTA Contrast Bug

White Continue button on KYC screen. Literally unblocks the funnel. CSS only.

S12

2 weeks

4-Email Drip Sequence

Educate > Anticipate > Prime > Act. Warms every user during 24-48hr activation wait.

 GREEN LIGHT CONDITION: KYC completion up +5pp AND activation rate up +5pp vs baseline within 3 weeks → Phase 2 launches

PHASE 2: EXTERNAL CAMPAIGN | Weeks 4-8 | Budget Rs 80-120L | Market-facing GTM

Core Message

Upstox is now built for first-time investors

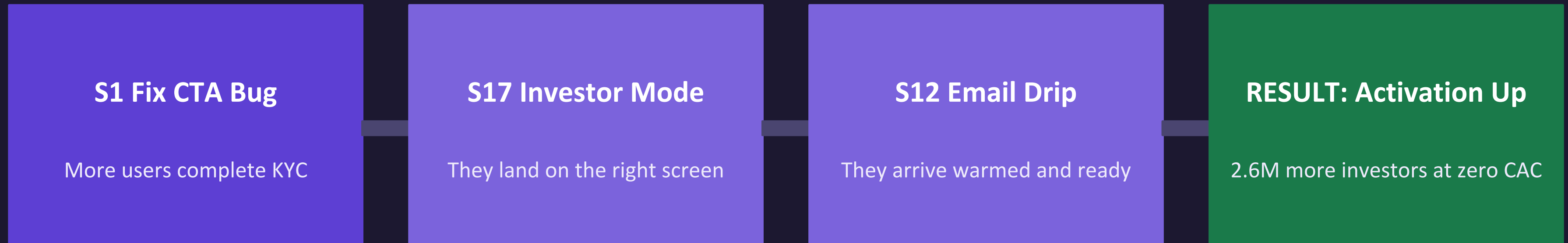
Audiences

Segment A: New first-timers
Segment B: Dormant reactivation

Channels

YouTube, Instagram, WhatsApp referral, regional language creatives

MVP Coherence Argument



The PM Argument

- All three require zero new product capabilities to ship
- They attack the exact same funnel stage: KYC completion to first trade placed
- Combined effort: 3.5 engineer-weeks. Combined RICE impact: 16,000+ adjusted units
- They establish the measurement baseline for every phase that follows

Product Roadmap

Sprint 1 - NOW

Weeks 1-3

- S17 - Default new accounts to Investor mode (1 day)
- S1 - Fix CTA contrast bug (1 day)
- S12 - 4-email activation drip sequence (2 weeks)

Sprint 2 - NEXT

Weeks 4-10

- S19 - Onboarding intent screen: Beginner / Trader / Investor (3 wks)
- S21 - 30-day new investor milestone journey checklist (3 wks)
- S20 - What should I buy? curated starter collections (3 wks)
- S4 - Named Aadhaar mismatch error + 3-path recovery (2 wks)
- S3 - Contextual micro-copy at each sensitive KYC step (2 days)
- S10 - Delay notification permissions to post-first-trade (1 day)
- S6 - Guided recovery email triggered on KYC dropout (2 wks)
- S5 - Stuck? support button at each KYC step (2 wks)

Sprint 3 - LATER

Weeks 11+

- S22 - Designed first-trade celebration screen + shareable card (2 wks)
- S14 - WhatsApp-native activation updates (3 wks)
- S11 - Bilingual learning content: English and Hindi in-app (2 wks)
- S13 - Risk profiling questionnaire during activation wait (3 wks)
- S2 - Friendly Google Auth failure error message (1 wk)
- S16 - Investor/Trader mode switch visible on home screen (1 wk)
- S18 - App accessibility: custom font size and display scaling (2 wks)

GTM Strategy

Phase 1: Silent Launch

Weeks 1-3 | Internal GTM | No external spend

No external announcement

S17, S1, S12 are fixes to existing flows - not new features. Silent launch to measure baseline improvement with no marketing noise.

Establish measurement baseline

Record pre-launch KPIs: KYC completion rate, 30-day activation rate, and CTA click-through before any change ships.

Green Light Condition

KYC completion up 5pp AND activation rate up 5pp vs pre-Phase 1 baseline - both must be true before Phase 2 budget is released.

Phase 2: External Campaign

Weeks 4-8 | Market-facing | Budget Rs 80-120L

Core message

Upstox is now built for first-time investors. Campaign positions directly against Groww's beginner ownership with a superior guided experience.

Primary audiences

Segment A: New first-timer acquisition. Segment B: Dormant reactivation - the never-traded accounts already in the funnel.

Channels

YouTube pre-roll, Instagram reels, WhatsApp referral amplification, and regional language creatives for Tier 2 and 3 cities.

Data-gated unlock

Phase 2 only launches after Phase 1 green light conditions are confirmed.

Success Metrics

+8pp

KYC Completion Rate

Baseline: Measured pre-launch
Timeline: 4 weeks post-ship | Driver: S1 + S17

+5pp

Activation Rate

Baseline: Funded + first trade within 30 days
Timeline: 6 weeks post-ship | Driver: S17 + S12

+15%

CTA Click-Through (KYC)

Baseline: Pre vs post contrast fix
Timeline: Immediate post S1 | Driver: S1

>35%

Email Open Rate (Drip)

Baseline: Industry avg approx 22%
Timeline: Weeks 2-3 of drip | Driver: S12

+5pp

D7 Retention

Baseline: Users returning within 7 days of first trade
Timeline: 6 weeks post-ship | Driver: S12 + S17

+3pp

Dormant Reactivation

Baseline: Never-traded accounts who invest post-campaign
Timeline: 8 weeks post Phase 2 | Driver: Phase 2 GTM

The Takeaway

1

The Door Is Built

Upstox has 13M registered users and functional infrastructure. The hard access problem is solved.

2

Most Are Still Outside

40-60% dormancy. 35% KYC dropout. Invisible walls at every stage of Aakash's journey.

3

One Sprint Changes Everything

3.5 engineer-weeks. Three fixes. One funnel window. Rs 260Cr opportunity at zero additional CAC.

Upstox has built the door.

The problem is that most people are still standing outside it.